

can someone help me find sources on Claude Code's carbon footprint?

Posted by u/ActualHovercraft3257 • 0 points • 9 comments

Ironically there's plenty of sources (when googling) for estimating the impact of OpenAI ChatGPT queries but the average person probably (unfortunately) uses ChatGPT a few times a day/week.

Claude Code is in a league of its own. Developers have Claude code acting as autocomplete. Every keystroke during an ai sycophants coding journey can potentially incur another "query" against anthropics ai. And don't get me started on agents! People pride themselves on running multiple agents in parallel all day long.

My theory is that Claude Code, and by extension Anthropic, has a far more costly carbon footprint and is far worse for the environment than basically any other tool on the market rn.

Can anyone link me to research papers or citations around this? Fine if you prove me wrong. I just want to know MORE.

Comments

u/jaegernut • 1 points • 2026-03-29 14:43 UTC

Consider how much hardware they are gobbling up too. Leaving overpriced leftovers for consumers.

u/Adorable-Fault-5116 • 1 points • 2026-03-29 08:21 UTC

Inference is barely worth measuring, which is why AI companies concentrate the argument there so heavily. This is how people can say that scrolling tiktok for 5 minutes costs a hundred chatgpt queries or whatever. It's a distraction.

The actual cost is training and the infra build out required to support that training, and the cost is not just energy usage, but non-renewable resource usage, the short-term nature of that usage (graphics cards last maybe 3-5 years before they will be replaced), and the environmental and social impact that this infra has on communities.

u/JeffTheMasterr • 2 points • 2026-03-29 01:35 UTC

I know a site, it's not counting prompts or keystrokes though, I think it's about maybe the web hosting carbon?

[<https://www.websitecarbon.com/website/chatgpt-com/>]
(<https://www.websitecarbon.com/website/chatgpt-com/>) \- F rating

<https://www.websitecarbon.com/website/claude-ai/> \- F rating

u/ActualHovercraft3257 • 2 points • 2026-03-29 04:34 UTC

Thanks, though this looks to just speak to the website visits rather than api interactions via the cli, no?

u/ActualHovercraft3257 • 1 points • 2026-03-29 01:02 UTC

And it doesn't address the scale of Claude infra

u/Puzzleheaded-Rope808 • 0 points • 2026-03-29 00:26 UTC

So let me get this straight. Claude code can write what would take hours worth of electricity on a computer in minutes, thereby saving carbon, and you think that's bad? Your computer running to type out your paragraph used about as much energy as several queries.

u/ActualHovercraft3257 • 1 points • 2026-03-29 01:01 UTC

I don't think this is true actually

u/Puzzleheaded-Rope808 • 0 points • 2026-03-29 01:18 UTC

You're kidding right now. Are you a bot? Of course it's true. Just the power consumption of your display alone would equal that.

You can't be serious right now. This is like "duh" 101

u/ActualHovercraft3257 • 1 points • 2026-03-29 04:37 UTC

I think there are a lot of assumptions being made around my person consumption of power and around the power required by Claude ai throughout a day of frequent use (every few minutes or hours for a software developer over an 8 hour workday).

Even then, if someone using Claude cli all day equates to some fraction of my own personal (non-ai) power consumption it would still be power that isn't truly necessary for daily life.

u/Catriks • 0 points • 2026-03-28 23:06 UTC

You can't just take a total number of carbon produced and make any kind of meaningful conclusions from it. It has to be divided with the amount of work done to mean anything.

Its like comparing a semi truck fuel consumption to a minivan and saying how bad the truck is for the environment because it pollutes more per 100 km. But if the trucks cargo was transported with 50 minivans to do the same amount of work, there would be significantly more overall pollution because they have lower efficiency and it is logistically much more difficult.